those slaughtered in the state, by the machinations of all of these agent provocateurs and their Pakistani masters.

On 26 October 1947, if Maharaja Hari Singh had taken a reality check, he would have been dismayed. He had already signed the Instrument of Accession with India; the postscript of this deal was the legitimisation of the political transition of Sheikh Abdullah into a position of political power in the state. After the appointment of Mehr Chand Mahajan as the Prime Minister, strong winds were rattling the locks of Sheikh Abdullah's prison cell. As Mahajan began to come to terms with the complexities of his office, he discovered that the Maharaja, through Deputy Prime Minister R. L. Batra, was in serious negotiations with Sheikh Abdullah on the nature of his release. The Maharaja was a beleaguered man and options were fast running out for him. These negotiations culminated in the release of Sheikh Abdullah on 29 September 1947. However, some weeks prior to his release, Abdullah was shifted from the Bhadarwah Jail of the Doda district in Jammu to the Badami Bagh cantonment hospital in Srinagar. For a few days, in the hospital, Abdullah had a regular visitor in the Maharaja's brother-in-law, Nishchant Chand Katoch.[3] These meetings were to prepare Abdullah for his audience with the Maharaja. A technicality demanded that Abdullah offer the Maharaja *nazar* or a tribute of gold coins. Abdullah had none. Thereupon, one Shyam Sunder Lal Dhar gave him some gold coins which he, in turn, presented to the Maharaja. It appears that some sort of deal was struck between the two men as a few days later Abdullah was formally released, along with other National Conference leaders. The Muslim Conference leaders, however, remained in jail.

For the Maharaja, this was a great comedown since he had to now do business with the very man who had challenged the legitimacy of his rule. For Abdullah, his borrowed gold coins not only bought him his freedom, but also a seat at the high table with the Maharaja. The middle-class shawl maker's son had come a long way in his political struggle.

If the Maharaja had reflected on his actions from the time he was positioning himself to succeed his uncle, the Late Maharaja Pratap Singh, to the throne, he would have gathered that his opposition to British hegemony